

Reference: 337399

Date: 29 September 2016

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Information requests

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Freedom of Information: Right to know request

Thank you for your request for information dated 7 September for a list of all amateur radio call signs that Ofcom holds in its database, the type of licence, how long they are reserved for and when they were allocated along with the policy or procedures for reserving unsuitable or inappropriate call signs from allocation. This has been considered under the Freedom of Information Act 2000 ('the Act').

Please find attached a list of all call signs that are allocated or reserved with the type of licence. For the missing licence type, there is a published regime which denotes the call sign prefix for each licence product:

<http://licensing.ofcom.org.uk/radiocommunication-licences/amateur-radio/guidance-for-licensees/amateur-radio-call-signs/737317>

For Club licences, the call signs are the same regime as for Full licences. Therefore, we do not know if the call signs were allocated to a Full or Club licence.

We do not hold a list of call signs that are available. Due to a system change, the assignment of call signs is now done using an algorithm rather than "grabbing" from a list. We have a historic available call sign list which was disclosed in July 2016 (but is now likely to be out of date) and which can be found here:

<http://stakeholders.ofcom.org.uk/freedom-of-information/foi-responses/2016/july2016/285990/>

We are unable to provide how long the call signs are reserved for and when they were allocated as this would take the total time spent on your request over the 18-hour limit. Under section 12 of the Act, we are not obliged to comply with a request if it would exceed the 'appropriate limit', as set out in the Act. The appropriate limit for Ofcom is £450, calculated at a rate of £25 per person per hour; this equates to 18 hours of time.

We do not hold a policy on reserving unsuitable or inappropriate call signs for allocation. However, as a matter of conventional practice we do not issue call signs or parts of call signs that might spell out (English) words that we think are likely to be generally offensive or which may lead to undue on-air bullying of the licensee. You will find a list of these reserved call

signs within the attachment as above. It does change over time, as taste and social tolerance change.

In addition to the list of potentially offensive call signs, we are required by Art 19.46 *et seq* of the Radio Regulations not to allow call signs that might be confused with internationally accepted signals. That is therefore an international obligation. For example, 'SOS'. In addition, there is an international list of so-called 'Q-Codes'. These are three-letter codes that mean something. For example, 'QSL' means 'Are you receiving' (when transmitted first) and 'Yes, I am receiving' (when sent as a reply). You can find further information here: https://www.itu.int/dms_pubrec/itu-r/rec/m/R-REC-M.1172-0-199510-I!!PDF-E.pdf. Our licensing system has been programmed not to allow these as suffixes.

I hope this information is helpful.

Yours sincerely

Julia Snape

If you are unhappy with the response or level of service you have received in relation to your request from Ofcom, you may ask for an internal review. If you ask us for an internal review of our decision, it will be treated as a formal complaint and will be subject to an independent review within Ofcom. We will acknowledge the complaint and inform you of the date by which you might expect to be told the outcome.

The following outcomes are possible:

- the original decision is upheld; or
- the original decision is reversed or modified.

Timing

If you wish to exercise your right to an internal review **you should contact us within two months of the date of this letter**. There is no statutory deadline for undertaking internal reviews and it will depend upon the complexity of the case. However, we aim to conclude all such reviews within 20 working days, and up to 40 working days in exceptional cases. We will keep you informed of the progress of any such review. If you wish to request an internal review, you should contact:

Steve Gettings
The Secretary to the Corporation
Ofcom
Riverside House
2a Southwark Bridge Road
London SE1 9HA

If you are not content with the outcome of the internal review, you have the right to apply directly to the Information Commissioner for a decision. The Information Commissioner can be contacted at:

Information Commissioner's Office
Wycliffe House
Water Lane
Wilmslow
Cheshire
SK9 5AF